

# Chicago Tribune



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## SERVING UP FOOD — AND SOME MISHAPS

By Talia Soglin  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Food delivery robots are now ubiquitous in parts of Chicago, cruising down crowded sidewalks and scooting themselves through crosswalks. But sometimes the robots get themselves into pickles as they deliver tuna sandwiches and other fare to the city's human denizens.

The lunch boxes on wheels have tumbled down subway stairs, crashed through bus shelters and even, in one case, learned to say “sorry.”

The sidewalk bots, operated by Serve and Coco Robotics, both California-based companies, have cruised thousands of Windy City miles without significant incident in recent months.

But there have been some significant episodes — such as one case this year in which a robot collided

Sidewalk robots have tumbled down subway stairs, crashed through bus shelters and even learned to say ‘sorry’

**Above:** A food delivery robot from Serve Robotics parks along West Grand Avenue on Tuesday in Chicago's West Town neighborhood near where a food delivery robot previously crashed through a bus shelter glass.  
**BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

head-on with a Divvy biker in Lakeview.

Some incidents, like the bus shelter crashes, have become flashpoints in an ongoing debate: In a city where advocates have long argued that pedestrians are sidelined by cars on the city's public way, should those pedestrians have to cede the sidewalk to robots?

“I take it on good faith that both companies know that they have a very low margin for error and tolerance from the public for things like this,” said Ald. Brian Hopkins, in whose 2nd Ward a Coco delivery robot collided with a city bus shelter March 24, leaving glass shards strewn across the sidewalk.

The robots are on trial as the companies operate under a pilot program that expires in May 2027. Chicago's City Council would need to take action to allow the robots to stay in Chicago after

See **ROBOTS** on Page A8

## City paid baffling legal invoices

A 69-hour workday? Chicago didn't blink at impossible shifts

By Joe Mahr and Jason Meisner  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

For one attorney's work over a 24-hour stretch, a law firm billed the city of Chicago for 69 hours.

In invoices submitted from another city-hired firm, one staffer was logged working more than 24 hours a day 15 times. For another staffer, at least seven times.

The city paid them all.

Private law firms have submitted tens of thousands of invoices worth hundreds of millions of dollars to the city over the past decade for work to defend federal civil rights lawsuits related to police misconduct. In 2025 alone, the city paid these firms more than \$20 million to fight the claims of people whose criminal convictions were overturned in court.

These invoices — hours logged, money paid — represent one of the only available avenues to evaluate how well the Chicago Department of Law is vetting massive bills for which taxpayers ultimately are on the hook.

When the Tribune obtained and analyzed a decade's worth of these bills, it found the city failed to catch at least 40 instances when a firm billed Chicagoans for a person alleged to have worked more than 24 hours in a day.

Beyond those impossibilities, the analysis found that when the city's system flags a billing entry for extra scrutiny because someone worked more than 10 hours in a day, a potential sign of overbilling, the city routinely still pays.

These findings come after a Tribune investigation detailed how

See **BILLS** on Page A4

### ELECTION 2026

## Bailey seeks distance from Trump

But MAGA shadow still looms over Republican gubernatorial candidate

By Rick Pearson  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

After Darren Bailey last month won the Illinois Republican Party nomination for governor, he quickly tried to separate himself from President Donald Trump, declaring, “I am my own person” and that “there will be no outside influence dictating anything that we do here in Illinois.”

Yet less than two weeks later, there was Bailey, sitting across from Trump's daughter-in-law Lara Trump inside Chicago's Trump International Hotel & Tower. In an interview for her Fox News show, Bailey urged the president's U.S. Justice Department or the FBI to come to Illinois to inves-



Republican gubernatorial candidate Darren Bailey speaks to the media after his primary victory at an Illinois GOP unity breakfast in Naperville on March 18. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

tigate “waste and fraud at massive levels” without offering any proof.

It was just one example of the contradictions that have become a feature of the downstate farmer's second bid to challenge Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker for the state's top office, reflecting few lessons learned from his first unsuccessful effort or even from the stumblings of his GOP rivals in the March primary campaign.

Bailey 2.0 was supposed to be a chastened, more humble candidate after his nearly 13-percent-age-point loss to Pritzker four years ago. But while he no longer declares Chicago a “hellhole,” as he did in 2022, and professes to better appreciate the city and suburbs, his social media remains filled with accounts of city crime and his vows

See **BAILEY** on Page A6

### ‘COMED FOUR’ TRIAL

## Case that once rocked state politics now on shaky ground

By Jason Meisner  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Three years ago, the “ComEd Four” trial alleging a massive conspiracy to bribe then-House Speaker Michael Madigan was headed toward a stunning guilty-on-all-counts conclusion, cementing its place as a pillar in the state's long, sordid history of corruption cases.

Or so it seemed at the time.

Now, after a pair of Supreme Court rulings on central issues like bribery and false statements, followed by a lightning-quick reversal by a Chicago appeals

court, the case that once rocked Illinois politics is on an increasingly shaky foundation.

Last week, a three-judge panel for the 7th Circuit U.S. Court of Appeals took only a few hours after hearing arguments to announce it would reverse the convictions of two of the ComEd Four defendants, ex-CEO Anne Pramaggiore and retired lobbyist Michael McClain, who were ordered released from prison “forthwith.”

The development has left the U.S. attorney's office in the

See **CASE** on Page A11

### State's 1st female House majority leader dies

Democratic state Rep. Barbara Flynn Currie was a champion for progressive causes and her lengthy stint as Illinois' first female majority leader opened doors for more women in the legislature. She died Thursday at 85. **Chicagoland, Page A2**



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#### WEATHER FORECAST

**TODAY** H: 51 L: 31  
**MON.** H: 53 L: 46  
**TUE.** H: 74 L: 50  
Complete details on Page A20

#### INDEX

Almanac ..... A15  
Crossword ... In Comics  
Editorials ..... B1

Horoscope ... In Comics  
Letters ..... B3  
Obituaries ..... A16

Rides ..... G7  
Success ..... G4  
Television ..... D9

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